

PAIN AND STRESS JOURNAL

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Discover the relationship between stress, muscle tension, and increased pain levels.
2. Identify any patterns of times, places, or activities that trigger increased pain.
3. Identify sources of stress that are associated with increased pain.
4. Identify patterns of relief activities that are commonly being used to reduce pain or stress.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Medical Issues
- Phase of Life Problems
- Somatization

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Review the form for collection of data when this assignment is given to the client. Answer any questions about the type of data that the form requests. Review the completed form with the client to discover any patterns of the place, activity, or time that is associated with increased pain experiences. Also note how stress levels may be associated with increased pain. Review the sources of stress that may be triggering pain and prepare the client for training in stress management techniques focused on these sources of stress. Be alert for any adaptive stress reduction techniques the client is currently using so that they can be reinforced.

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Chronic pain is both a producer of stress and exacerbated by stress. It is important for people suffering from chronic pain to recognize this fact and attempt to minimize the amount of stress in their lives and to develop effective coping skills and techniques to reduce stress that cannot be avoided. The reduction of stress and its accompanying muscle tension will bring about increased pain management and control. This exercise will help you and your therapist discover when chronic pain seems to be most severe and the nature of the stressors that accompany or trigger the increase in pain. Keeping a journal is a difficult task that requires consistent discipline to make entries on a daily basis.

The journal outline form is designed to help you focus your attention on pain and stress management during the treatment process. You are asked to make an entry at least once a day, beginning with writing the date and time in the lefthand column. You may make more than one entry if there are several instances of severe pain during 1 day. After entering the date and time, record where you were when the pain was severe under the Place heading. Next, record the degree of the pain on a scale of 1 to 100, with 100 being the most severe possible, under the Pain Severity heading. Next, record what it is you were doing while the pain increased in severity under the Activity heading. Record the degree of stress you feel you were under on a scale of 1 to 10, with 10 being the most severe stress in the Stress Severity heading. Next, record the reason you believe you were feeling so much stress under the Stress Source heading. Finally, record any actions you took to relieve the pain or reduce the stress under the Relief Actions heading (include any nonmedication or behavioral actions). Repeat these entries on a consistent daily basis and then bring the data to your counselor for review and processing.

Entry 1 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	
	Pain Severity (1–100)	
	Activity	
	Stress Severity (1–10)	
	Stress Source	
	Relief Actions	

Entry 2 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	
	Pain Severity (1–100)	
	Activity	
	Stress Severity (1–10)	
	Stress Source	
	Relief Actions	

Entry 3 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	
	Pain Severity (1–100)	
	Activity	
	Stress Severity (1–10)	
	Stress Source	
	Relief Actions	

Entry 4 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	
	Pain Severity (1–100)	
	Activity	
	Stress Severity (1–10)	
	Stress Source	
	Relief Actions	

Entry 5 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	
	Pain Severity (1–100)	
	Activity	
	Stress Severity (1–10)	
	Stress Source	
	Relief Actions	

Entry 6 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	 _____ _____
	Pain Severity (1–100)	 _____ _____
	Activity	 _____ _____ _____
	Stress Severity (1–10)	 _____ _____ _____
	Stress Source	 _____ _____ _____
	Relief Actions	 _____ _____ _____

Entry 7 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	
	Pain Severity (1–100)	
	Activity	
	Stress Severity (1–10)	
	Stress Source	
	Relief Actions	

Entry 8 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	
	Pain Severity (1–100)	
	Activity	
	Stress Severity (1–10)	
	Stress Source	
	Relief Actions	

Entry 9 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	
	Pain Severity (1–100)	
	Activity	
	Stress Severity (1–10)	
	Stress Source	
	Relief Actions	

Entry 10 Date and Time: _____ _____	Place	
	Pain Severity (1–100)	
	Activity	
	Stress Severity (1–10)	
	Stress Source	
	Relief Actions	